

Spotting Online Tricks: Understanding Deceptive Patterns and Learning to Navigate Them

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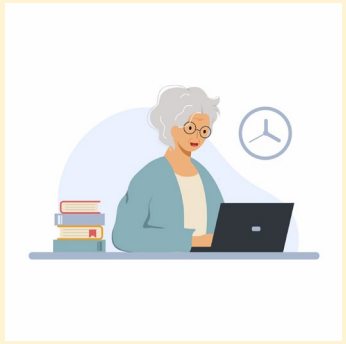
October 27, 2026

Digital services are now part of our everyday lives



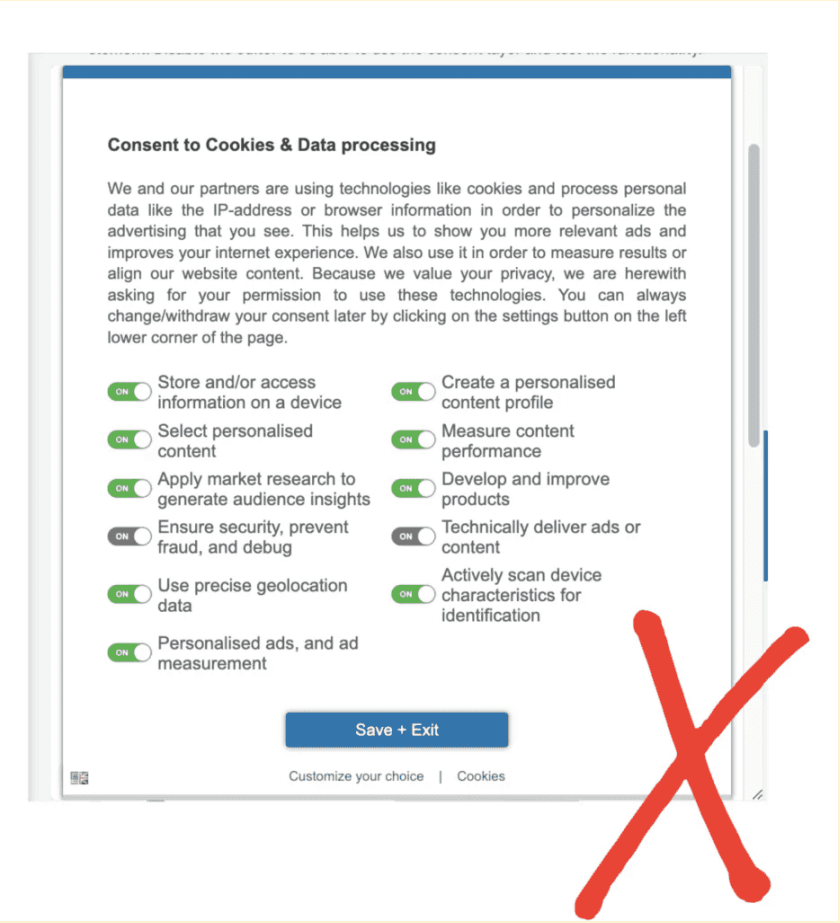








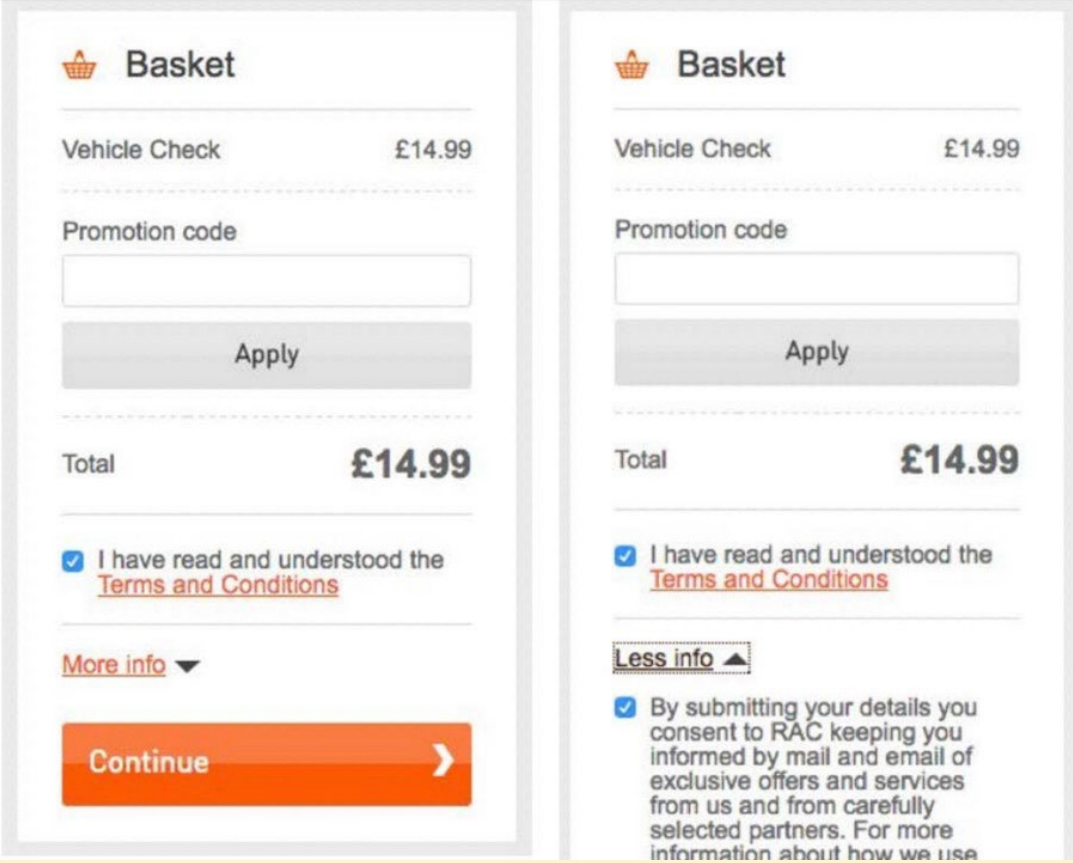
But are our online choices always what they seem?



- A cookie banner with too many options to easily understand.
- All data processing categories pre-selected.
- Users may click “Save & Exit” without knowing what they agreed to.

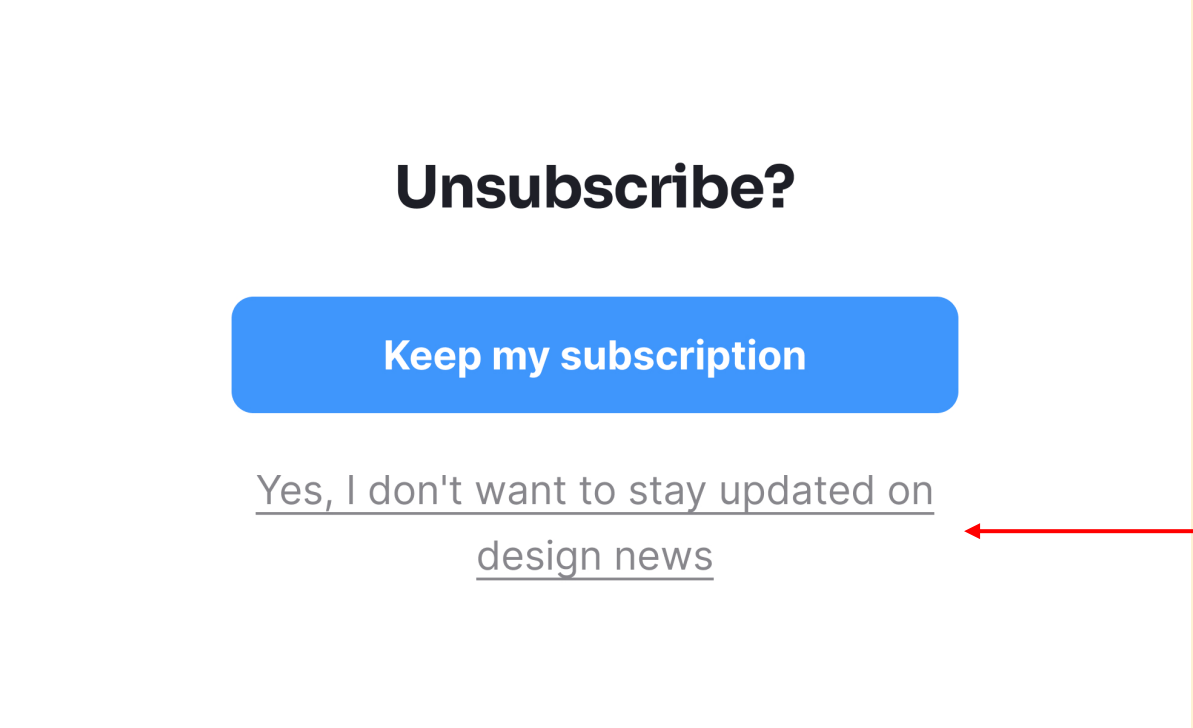
What did I just agree to?

But are our online choices always what they seem?



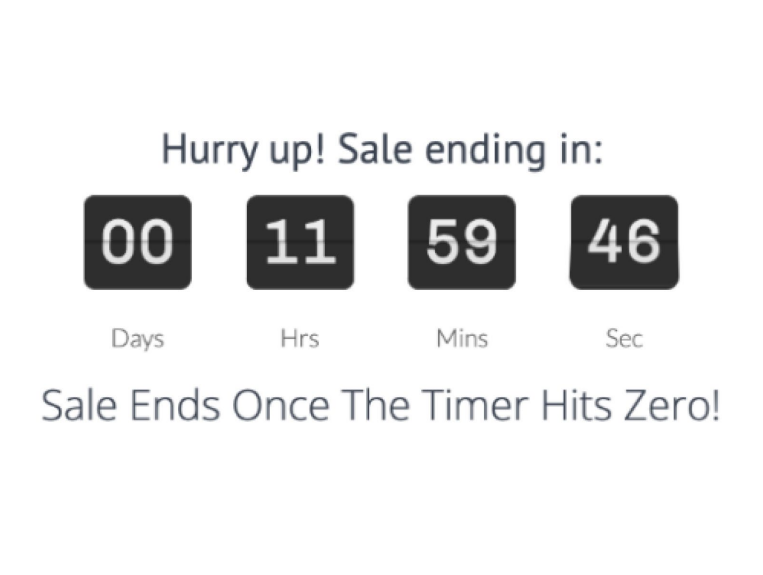
- Important **information** is **hidden** where users may overlook it.
  - For Rac.co.uk, the option for users to “opt out of sharing information and email spam” is hidden in “More info”.

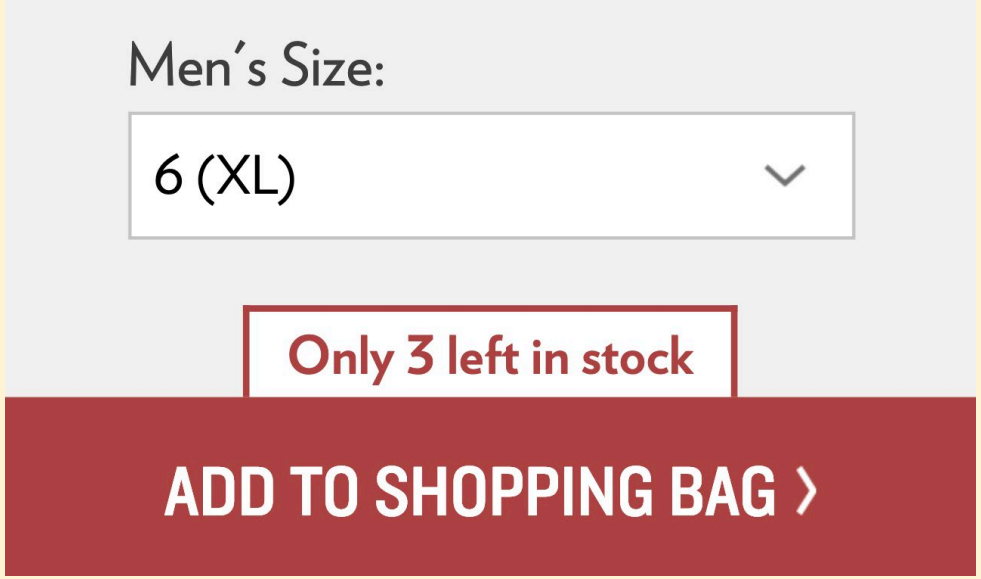
But are our online choices always what they seem?



Small, faded text: Makes the unsubscribe option hard to notice.

But are our online choices always what they seem?



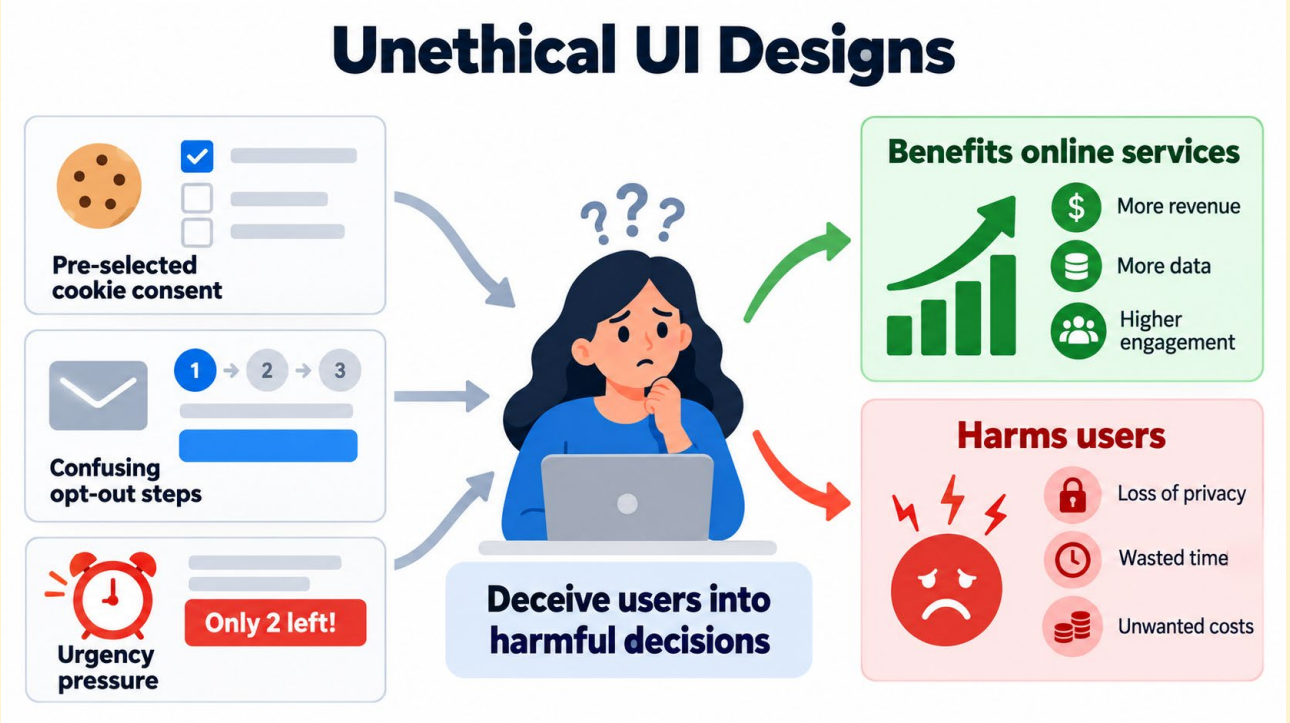


This may not be true. The shopping platform might simply be creating a **false sense of urgency**.

Deceptive patterns (DPs)

- These UI designs are everywhere, e.g., nearly 76% of sites and apps.

- Known as **deceptive patterns**, these designs manipulate users into unintended choices.
    - **Benefit online services at users' expense**.



Will Deceptive Patterns Disappear Anytime Soon?

Probably not.



Unclear boundaries

The line between persuasion and illegal manipulation is often vague (e.g., FTC discussions).

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Limited enforcement

Regulators cannot address every deceptive design due to limited resources.

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Room for exploitation

These gaps allow online services to continue using deceptive patterns.

What can we do as users?

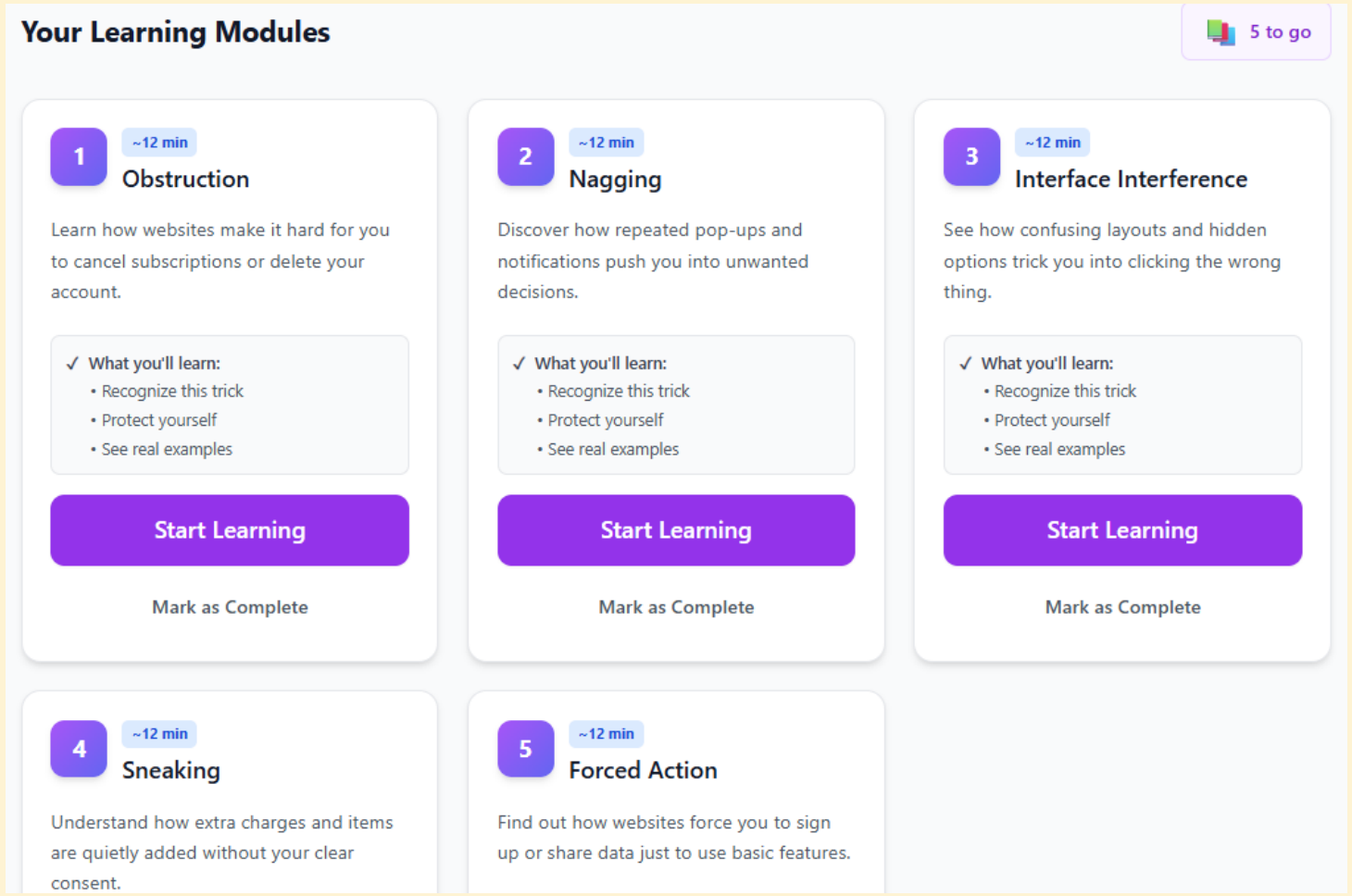
Be aware
Recognize common deceptive patterns.

Make intentional choices
Check settings and choose more privacy-friendly options.

Share and discuss
Help raise awareness with others.

DPTrek: Learn to Spot Deceptive Patterns Through Practice

Practice recognizing online tricks in **realistic**, **risk-free situations**.



1 EXPERIENCE

Try realistic interfaces without real-world risk.

2 REFLECT & LEARN

See how design steers choices, and why it matters.

3 EXPERIMENT

Practice spotting and navigating deceptive patterns.

Collaboration and support

A cross-college, cross-cluster collaboration at the University of Central Florida.



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CS/CECS · Cybersecurity



Yao Li

SMST/CECS · Cybersecurity



YunYing (Susan) Zhong

Rosen College · DAT

Research Support & Growth

Early community partnership enabled participant recruitment and supported the project's development.

01 **Richard Tucker Gerontology Applied Research Award**

LIFE at UCF · Helped recruit 38 older adult participants in the early project stage

02 **UCF Seed Funding Program**

Institutional support for continued research development

03 **NSF SaTC 2.0: EDU · Award #2520321**

Experiential Learning of Dark Patterns for Cybersecurity and Privacy

Community impact & research output

Peer-reviewed research, recognition, and community outreach

COMMUNITY OUTREACH

Legacy Pointe Health Fairs

2025 · 2026

Presentation at LIFE





RESEARCH OUTPUT

01

CHI 2025 | BEST PAPER AWARD

From Awareness to Action: The Effects of Experiential Learning on Educating Users about Dark Patterns

Jingzhou Ye · Yao Li · Wenting Zou · Xueqiang Wang

02

IEEE S&P 2026

Understanding and Analyzing Privacy Risks in Mobile Consent-Management Platforms

Jingzhou Ye* · Fares Alharbi* · Luyi Xing · Xueqiang Wang

03

IEEE S&P 2026

When Designers Meet GenAI: Understanding the Role of Prompt-to-Design Generators in Privacy Dark Patterns

Jingzhou Ye · Zhaojie Hu · Yao Li · Xueqiang Wang

Try out our interactive learning platform

Explore DPTrek, talk with the UCF research team, and take home simple tips for making safer, more confident online choices.

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Thank You!

Questions?

